Communication and Culture

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2026

Overview

1. Proverbs and Elaborate Expressions
2. Chengyu
3. Auspicious and Inauspicious Words
4. Politeness and Speech Styles
5. Japanese Honorifics
6. Cultural Scripts
7. Indirectness in Japanese

Speaking Well Is More Than Grammar

linguistic competence	saying it grammatically
communicative competence	saying the right thing, to the right person, in the right way

This week, across East and Southeast Asia: proverbs and set phrases, lucky and unlucky words, speech styles and honorifics, and cultural scripts for how to talk

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Proverbs Speak for You

- Central to communication, especially in **Malay**
- Express social norms and values
- **Depersonalize** advice: not my opinion, traditional wisdom

Malay Proverbs

(1) Ada hujan, ada panas, ada hari boleh balas.
exist rain exist heat exist day can repay
"Every deed, good or bad, will be repaid in kind." [zsm]

(2) Sedikit-sedikit, lama-lama jadi bukit.
little-little long-long become hill
"Little by little, over time, it becomes a hill." [zsm]

Small, patient actions bring big results

The Pantun: A Quatrain in Two Halves

Pisang emas bawa belayar,	The golden plantain carried on a voyage;
Masak sebiji di atas peti;	One ripens on top of the chest.
Hutang emas boleh dibayar,	A debt of gold can be repaid;
Hutang budi dibawa mati.	A debt of kindness lasts until death.

The first two lines set an image; the last two carry the meaning, linked by rhyme and indirect association. See *Connecting the dots: The case of foreshadow and meaning in pantun*, Nazima Versay Kudus and Melati Desa (2022)

Elaborate Expressions: Four Syllables, ABAC

	literally	means
หูป่าตาเถื่อน *hǔu-pàa-taa-thùan*	ear-forest-eye-wild	ignorant
พูดอย่างทำอย่าง *phûut-yàaŋ-tham-yàaŋ*	speak-kind-do-kind	say one thing, do another

Four-syllable compounds (ABAC, ABCB) are common across Thai, Lao, Vietnamese and Chinese, and a mark of fluent, vivid speech

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Chengyu 成语: Set Phrases from the Classics

- Typically **four characters**, from history or classical literature
- Partly or wholly **non-compositional**
- Work as single words, but more vivid

There is no definitive list: lexicons range from a few hundred to 50,000 or more, and there are many excellent (paper) dictionaries

Some Chengyu

(3) 守 株 待 兔

shǒu zhū dài tù

guard tree stump wait rabbit

“to expect fortune without any effort” [cmn]



(4) 分 崩 离 析

fēn bēng lí xī

divide rupture leave split apart

“to completely fall apart” [cmn]

Image from Yumcha Studios

Many Come from Stories

1. A farmer of Song rests under a tree in his field
2. A rabbit runs into the tree and dies: a free dinner
3. He leaves his plough, and waits by the tree for the next one
4. None comes; his fields go to ruin, and the village laughs

Told in the *Han Feizi* (3rd century BCE).
https://www.tutormandarin.net/en/holding-a-tree-and-waiting-for-a-rabbit/

Where Chengyu Are Used

genre	sentences	types	tokens	per 100 sents
story	1,226	79	90	7.3
news	2,138	108	161	7.5
essay	816	103	127	15.6
tourism	3,280	187	388	11.8
total	7,460	427	766	10.3

Chengyu in Chinese translations of English texts (Ho et al., 2014). The essay, *The Cathedral and the Bazaar*, has the most, fitting its intellectual tone

Chengyu Travel: Japanese and Korean

Mandarin	四面楚歌	*sìmiàn chǔgē*
Japanese	四面楚歌	*shimen soka*
Korean	사면초가	*samyeon choga*

四面楚歌 “songs of Chu on four sides”: surrounded by enemies. Used most in Chinese, then Korean, then Japanese. Not all are Chinese: Japanese 一石二鳥 *isseki nichō* “one stone, two birds” is said to translate the English proverb

Not So Different from Western Proverbs

画蛇添足 *huà shé tiān zú*	“draw legs on a snake” = add something superfluous
sour grapes, *lipstick on a pig*	also need interpreting

Western proverbs also come from classic works (Aesop, the Bible, Homer), and using them well is a sign of erudition. The fixed four-character form makes chengyu stand out more from ordinary text

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Cantonese: Lucky and Unlucky Sounds

auspicious			
八 eight	*baat3*	≈ 發 *faat3*	prosper
桔 tangerine	*gat1*	≈ 吉 *gat1*	luck
魚 fish	*jyu4*	= 餘 *jyu4*	surplus
生菜 lettuce	*saang1 coi3*	≈ 生財 *saang1 coi4*	make money
inauspicious			
四 four	*sei3*	≈ 死 *sei2*	death
書 book	*syu1*	= 輸 *syu1*	lose
鞋 shoe	*haai4*	≈ 唉 *aai1*	a sigh
舌 tongue	*sit6*	= 蝕 *sit6*	lose money

So a pig's tongue is 豬脷 *zyu1 lei6*, as 利 *lei6* is "profit"; and tangerines are given in pairs at New Year: 大吉 "great luck"

Japanese: Lucky and Unlucky Words

auspicious 縁起の良いことば	
松 *matsu* pine	longevity, evergreen
竹 *take* bamboo	strength, uprightness
梅 *ume* plum	renewal: the first flower of spring
鯛 *tai* sea bream	≈ めでたい *medetai* “happy, auspicious”
inauspicious 縁起の悪いことば	
四 *shi* four	≈ 死 *shi* “death”
櫛 *kushi* comb	≈ 苦死 “suffering, death”
切る *kiru* cut	not at weddings: “sever a relationship”
落ちる *ochiru* fall	not before exams: “fail”

At weddings and New Year: 松竹梅, and no knives or combs as gifts

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Politeness Protects Face

positive face	the wish to be liked and approved of
negative face	the wish not to be imposed on

Requests, refusals and criticism are **face-threatening acts**; speakers soften them:

positive politeness	build closeness: Korean *banmal*, nicknames
negative politeness	show deference: honorifics, Javanese *krama*
off record	hint: Malay "Are you hungry?"
don't do the act	settle it first: Japanese *nemawashi*

Brown and Levinson (1987)

Speech Styles

- Many languages here have distinct **speech styles** (registers)
- They signal respect, distance and familiarity
- Marked in pronunciation, vocabulary, particles, morphology, syntax

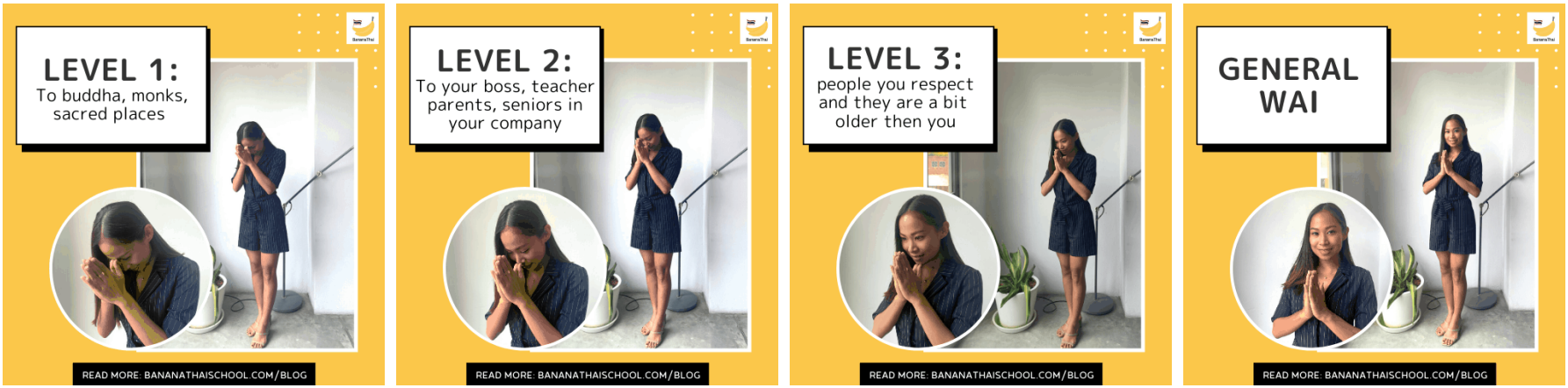
Most elaborate and codified in Javanese and Korean

Thai: Polite Particles and Styles

male speaker	ครับ *khráp*
female speaker	ค่ะ *khâ*

- Styles: public, consultative, personal (informal)
- Particles end a sentence or stand alone
- Consultative style: careful pronunciation, elevated words, nothing abrupt or negative

Thai: The Wai Shows Rank



The higher the other person's rank, the higher the hands and the deeper the bow; higher-ranked people may answer with a more relaxed gesture

Thai Royal Vocabulary ราชาศัพท์

	common	polite	royal
eat	กิน *kin*	รับประทาน *ráppratháan*	เสวย *sawə̌ə̀i*
sleep	นอน *nɔɔn*		บรรทม *banthom*

A whole vocabulary for the royal family, much of it from Khmer, Pali and Sanskrit; ทรง *song* turns an ordinary verb into a royal one

Javanese: Three Levels

ngoko	informal: close relations, thinking to oneself
madya	in between: shortened krama words, ngoko affixes
krama	formal: superiors and strangers

Choosing a level means weighing age, social standing and familiarity

Javanese: Different Words for Everything

	ngoko	*krama*
house	*omah*	*griya*
person	*wong*	*tiyang*
go	*lunga*	*késah*
cow	*sapi*	*lembu*
die	*mati*	*pejah*

"What": *apa* (ngoko), *napa* (madya), *punapa* (krama)

Sasak (Lombok): Three Levels, Fewer Words

“Have you eaten?”	
low	*Wah-m mangan kamu?*
mid	*Wah-m medaran side?*
high	*Sampun-m majengan pelinggih?*

The level depends on the addressee’s rank; high-level vocabulary is only about 180 words, far fewer than in Javanese

Korean: Speech Levels in the Verb Ending

"It is raining"		
plain	비가 온다	*bi-ga onda*
banmal	비가 와	*bi-ga wa*
familiar	비가 오네	*bi-ga one*
polite	비가 와요	*bi-ga wayo*
formal	비가 옵니다	*bi-ga omnida*

The speech style (*che*) depends on age, rank and relationship: *haeyo-che* is polite, *hapsyo-che* formal

Korean: Everyone Notices the Level

Uri-neun seoro hage-haneun sai.

"We are on *hage* terms with each other."

Nugu-hante banmal-eul haneun geo-ya?

"Who do you think you're speaking *banmal* to?"

Moving to *banmal* "putting down the language" signals closeness; levels shift as relationships change

Korean: Honouring the Person Talked About

	plain		honorific
go	가다 *gada*	subject -시-	가시다 *gasida*
eat	먹다 *meokda*	subject	드시다 *deusida*
give	주다 *juda*	humble	드리다 *deurida*
see, meet	보다 *boda*	humble	뵙다 *boepda*

Speech levels honour the **addressee**; these honour the **referent**, like Japanese *sonkeigo* and *kenjōgo*

Speech Styles Compared

- Javanese, Sasak, Korean: **structured levels**; Thai: royal vocabulary
- They encode **hierarchy**: age, rank, social distance
- Common in stratified societies with fixed roles

They reflect Confucian, Buddhist and local values. Knowing the styles is part of communicative competence

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Three Kinds of Japanese Honorific

teineigo	polite	towards the **addressee**: *-masu*
sonkeigo	honouring	raises the **referent** (usually the subject)
kenjōgo	humbling	lowers oneself or one's in-group

They show respect, social distance and group membership, and are part of everyday Japanese

Honouring and Humbling Verbs

	neutral	honouring	humbling
say	*iu*	*ossharu*	*mōsu*
go	*iku*	*irassharu*	*mairu*
do	*suru*	*nasaru*	*itasu*
eat	*taberu*	*meshiagaru*	*itadaku*
stay	*tomaru*	*o-tomari ni naru*	*o-tomari suru*

Regular verbs: honouring *o*-stem *ni naru*, humbling *o*-stem *suru*. Politeness is separate: *iu* vs *iimasu*. Kansai (especially Kyoto) has a lighter honorific *V-haru*: *tabe-haru*

In-Group and Out-Group: *uchi* and *soto*

(5) Chichi wa genki de ori-mas-u.
father TOP healthy COP be.HUM-POL-NPST
"(My) father is well." [jpn]

(6) O-tō-san wa o-genki des-u ka.
HON-father-HON TOP HON-health COP.POL-NPST Q
"Is (your) father well?" [jpn]

Humble for your own family, school or company; honouring for outsiders

Humbling: Doing Something for Someone Higher

(7) Sakai-san ga Suzuki-san ni chizu o o-kaki shi-mashi-ta.
Sakai-HON NOM Suzuki-HON DAT map ACC HON-draw do-POL-PST
"Mr Sakai drew a map for Mr Suzuki (humbly)." [jpn]

Women are expected to use more elaborate honorifics than men; the difference shrinks at the highest levels

Giving and Receiving

	plain	honorific
give to me / us	*kureru*	*kudasaru*
give to someone	*ageru*	*sashiageru*
receive	*morau*	*itadaku*

(8) Tanaka-san ga imōto ni o-kashi o tsukut-te
Tanaka-HON NOM younger.sister DAT HON-sweets ACC make-CONJ
kure-ta.
give.me-PST
"Mr Tanaka made sweets for my younger sister." [jpn]

Politer Means Longer

(9) 聞いて いい？
Kii-te ii?
“OK to ask?” [jpn]

(10) 聞かせて いただける と うれしい の です が。
Kika-se-te itadakeru to ureshii no desu ga.
“I would be delighted if I might be permitted to ask.” [jpn]

(11) ご協力 ください。
Go-kyōryoku kudasai.
“Your cooperation, please.” [jpn]

(12) ご協力 の 程 お願い 申し上げます。
Go-kyōryoku no hodo o-negai mōshiagemasu.
“We respectfully request the favour of your cooperation.” [jpn]

Who Talks Down, Who Talks Up

customer	salesperson
doctor	patient

Power is asymmetric: the higher-status speaker may be casual; the lower-status one stays polite

Names and Titles

さん *san*	Mr / Ms	adults of equal status
様 *sama*	Sir / Madam	higher status: guests, customers, deities
君 *kun*	—	juniors, boys, male friends
ちゃん *chan*	little ...	small children, cute things, close friends
たん *tan*	widdle ...	babies, moe characters
先輩 *senpai*	—	a senior colleague or classmate
先生 *sensei*	Dr / Prof	teachers, doctors, lawyers, authors
行 *yuki*	—	your own name, on a reply envelope

Often you use the role itself: engineer, director .... On a return envelope you write 行 after your own name; the office crosses it out and writes 様

Honorifics Are Taught

- A mark of **education** and upbringing
- Many Japanese want to improve theirs: plenty of guides and training courses

In my three-week induction at NTT: about 8 hours on honorific language, and another 8 or so on who sits where (in a room, a taxi, a train), how to pass business cards, and more

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Cultural Scripts

- Norms of communication, written in **semantic primes**:
  PEOPLE, GOOD, BAD, SAY, THINK
- No culture-specific words, so they compare across cultures

Developed by Anna Wierzbicka and colleagues

A Japanese Script: Apologize

[people think like this:]
if something bad happens to someone because of me,
I have to say something like this to this person:
"I feel something bad because of this"

Frequent apologies: they show empathy without accepting blame

Malay: Know the Proper Thing to Do

balasan	every deed, good or bad, is repaid in kind
think first	when I want to do something it is good if I think about it for some time
mind your mouth	think before speaking, so no one is hurt or shamed
sensitivity	avoid blunt or critical speech

Shaped by Islam and *adat* (custom): "It is good if a person knows what is good to do at all times". Western directness can clash with this

Malay: Don't Say "I Want"

instead of	"Can you make dinner?"
say	"Are you hungry?"

Saying "I want you to do this" for your own benefit is discouraged. The listener infers the request, and their autonomy is respected

Malay *menghormati* "Show Respect"

[X *menghormati* Y:]

X thinks good things about Y

X thinks things like this about Y:

- Y is someone above me
- I don't want Y to think anything bad about me

X wants Y to know this

because of this, when X is with Y

- X does some things, X doesn't do some other things
- X says some things, X doesn't say some other things

Malay: Humility

good	*merendah diri* “lowering oneself”, humility
bad	*sombong* “arrogant”

Westerners often find Malay discourse charming and respectful. Like Japanese, it values harmony, patience and deference, but its roots are in Islam. Modernization is changing these norms

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Japanese: Say It Indirectly

- Ambiguity avoids confrontation; posture, tone and body language carry meaning
- Disagreement happens privately, later
- 根回し *nemawashi* "preparing the roots": reach consensus one by one, before proposing anything

Kore-o yaru to ii desu ne.

"It would be good if this were done."

= my boss telling me "Do this"

Refusing Without Saying No

kentō-shimasu	"I will consider it" = probably not
maemuki-ni kentō-shimasu	"I will consider it positively" = I will do nothing

Refusals come as hesitation and vague language, keeping the peace

Silence and Back-Channelling

aizuchi: show you are listening	
agreement	*hai* “yes”, *sō desu ne* “so it is”, *sugoi* “wow”
surprise	*eeee?* “really?”, *hontō desu ka?* “is that true?”
grunts	*un*, *nnn* (neutral); *oo*, *hoh* (news); *aa*, *sa*, *ma* (stalling)

Silence is polite: it gives others time to think, and interrupting is rude. But a listener should make some sounds, especially on the phone. I notice Siri says *aha* when you speak, so you know it heard you

Deflect the Compliment

- Humility: compliments are **deflected**, not accepted
- Too much praise is embarrassing

Culturally Appropriate Communication

- Speaking well means the **appropriate** words, not just the right meaning
- We rarely notice how our own culture communicates
- The more fluent you are, the more people expect the cultural arts too

How is Czech communicative culture different from its neighbours'? From Asian cultures?

Acknowledgements and References

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